

Rethinking Morality in "Andha Yug": A Revisionist Exploration of Ethics Amidst Conflict

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ABSTRACT

This research paper explores morality and ethics in "Andha Yug" by Dharamvir Bharati through the theory of Revisionism. The researcher has investigated the moral dilemmas faced by the characters and their implications for challenging societal norms and reevaluating moral values within the context of war. Drawing upon textual analysis and critical interpretation, this research delves into the complex ethical terrain traversed by the characters in "Andha Yug." Through their actions and decisions, the play challenges conventional notions of right and wrong, inviting a revisionist reading that prompts a reassessment of moral values. The characters, caught in the aftermath of the *Mahabharata* war, grapple with guilt, regret, and the loss of moral compass, shedding light on the moral ambiguities inherent in times of conflict. The study examines key scenes and character interactions to explore the ways in which "Andha Yug" disrupts established moral frameworks. It investigates how the play confronts societal norms and prompts the audience to question the validity of traditional moral codes when confronted with the harsh realities of war. By presenting characters caught in moral dilemmas, the play emphasizes the importance of critical reflection and the reevaluation of ethical standards. Through its revisionist approach, "Andha Yug" challenges the audience to consider the consequences of blind adherence to ideologies and the profound impact of war on individual morality and societal values. By exploring the theory of revisionism in "Andha Yug" through the lens of morality and ethics, this research contributes to a deeper understanding of the play's significance in Indian literature and

theatre. It underscores the relevance of revisiting historical narratives and questioning established moral frameworks to foster critical thinking and moral introspection. Hence, the research offers insights into the enduring relevance of "Andha Yug" and its potential to provoke meaningful discussions on the nature of morality and ethics in times of conflict.

Keywords: *Mahabharata*, Andha Yug, Dharamvir Bharti, Revisionism, Mythology

According to narratologists, there is a basic difference between a 'story' and a 'plot'. A 'story' is the actual sequence of events as they happen, whereas the 'plot' describes the events that are edited, ordered, packaged and presented in what we recognize as a narrative. We can observe a similar difference between the ancient myths and their respective modern versions. Every village and house has different versions of the epics across generations. We cannot compare our epics to Greek or Nordic cultures because their stories stopped growing, and people can't relate to the same. The myths in our country kept reinventing with every generation using retellings, TV serials and movies. The creative liberties taken from the main sources and the thoughts of these characters are very much relevant to our existing culture.

The New Encyclopaedia Britannica defines myths as, "Myths are specific accounts of gods or superhuman beings involved in extraordinary events or circumstances in a time that is unspecified but which is understood as existing apart from ordinary human experience" (794). The numerous foreign invasions, migrations, subjugations and counter-attacks have decorated India into a melting pot of diversified cultures and voices. Hence, it is no wonder that through the passage of centuries, India has produced and continues to read and reread its mythical literary artifacts. Our epics and Puranas are an endless source of inspiration —for filmmakers, writers, or artists — and a large number of characters and threads take countless shapes and directions in

their hands. The retelling of Indian epics is not new — in fact, it is said that the Ramayana has 300 versions. Indian mythology is a measureless chest full of stories. These stories have inspired and influenced generations of people's imaginations, thinking, and understanding of life. These myths of India are intended to cover almost all the emotions and disagreements one could come across in life. They were written to amuse, teach morals and values, and inspire creativity and admiration. The need to retell these mythologies has been quite a probing topic for the writers of the 21st century, and in the last few years, we have seen the surfacing of the classical Indian myths, retold and reinvented by lenses that are pertinent for modern-day readers. The perspectives range from feminism and gender identity to the ambiguous nature of 'truth' and power; many different perspectives have been used to examine classic mythologies. All the retellings have been put in different perspectives, trying to show the picture of the society of that time. Borrowing a certain tale or character from ancient mythologies, then molding them into a new narrative that appeals to modern day audience, does not only heighten the popularity of mythology, but also contributes in popularizing those certain works of literature (Mohamed & Gamila 1).

The general idea behind the retellings is to try to satiate modern-day minds by exposing the relativity of the situation and circumstances rather than finding faults with the individual characters. R. K. Narayan, one of India's literary giants famous for his works based on literary realism, published a shortened version of The Ramayana. In an interview in 1988, R. K. Narayan talked about his works on classic narratives, i.e., the retellings of The Ramayana and The *Mahabharata*. According to him, the need to retell these stories was important. "They are symbolic and philosophical", he described. In the case of some writers dealing with essential elements of an ancient text can be a reward in itself.

On the other hand, others want to explore these works for contemporary questions or use the narratives to critique something in society. It has been acknowledged that Indian mythology is very much like Chinese whispers. Such stories have been told and retold for generations, resulting in the development of numerous sub-plots and new characters and events which have changed according to the perspectives of the storytellers over centuries. The concept of retelling these myths has given birth to a new breed of writers who have become immensely popular in the 21st century. *Jaya* by Devdutta Pattanaik, *Ajaya: Roll of the Dice* by Anand Neelakantan, *The Palace of Illusions* by Chitra Banerjee Divakaruni, *Shikhandi and Other Tales They Don't Tell You* by Devdutta Pattanaik, *Mrityunjaya: The Death Conqueror* by Shivaji Sawant, *The Shiva Trilogy* by Amish Tripathi and many more such retellings provide a different perspective on mythology and classic Indian stories.

In the context of the *Mahabharata*, we cannot deny that certain myths might have been invented to explain the incidents which were not acceptable to the changing mores. During the current age where the influence of postmodernity and globalization matters, the age-old myths still govern India's tradition, modes and general culture. It is intriguing to find modern Indian English Fiction employs mythical tales and characters to embody the spirits of modern-day India. These contemporary writers explore mythical themes and characters to revise the existing patterns, which led to a new stream of discourse, viz., revisionist mythology. Revisionism is a technique extensively used by postmodern authors in Literature and aims to narrate or retell an existing literary artifact from a different, divergent or contemporary perspective. The technique has especially been employed in retelling the mythical tales out of the presumption that such artifacts may be analysed, dissected and even delved into to come across patches of ambiguity that need to be cleared or patched up. Revisionism has not spared the great epics and brought

down the divine aura surrounding Gods to earthly grounds by equating their decisions and emotions to the stature of an ordinary being. In Andre Lefebvre's work *Translation, Rewriting and the Manipulation of Literary Fame* (2016), he states that, "All rewritings reflect a certain ideology and a poetics and as such manipulate literature to function in a given society in a given way. Rewriting is manipulation, undertaken in the service of power, and in its positive aspect can help in evolution of a literature and a society. Rewriting can introduce new concepts and new genres; new devices and the history of translation is the history also of literary innovation. But rewriting can also repress innovation, distort, and contain" (Lefebvre vii).

Moreover, it is astonishing to find revisionist literary practitioners questioning the plots of myths and legends that had for ages remained out of reach of scathing criticism. The social inequalities prevalent in our society are effectively showcased in the revisionist texts using the traditional plots. The revisionist tendencies in literature also incorporate waves of revivalism, for it brings to light the myths and legends which would have been otherwise forgotten in the fast pace of a technology-driven global world. Revisionism adds to the superiority of the celebrated myths, for it proves the richness, vibrancy and scope of plural thoughts embedded within the texts, thereby toning the charms of the tradition or religion of which it is an integral part. Chitra Banerjee Divakaruni in the "Author's Note" of her famed masterpiece *The Palace of Illusions* bluntly expresses her aim stating, "listening to the stories of Mahabharat as a young girl... I was left unsatisfied with the portrayals of the woman... (who) in some ways of the remained shadowy figures, their thoughts and motives mysterious, their emotions portrayed only when affected the lives of the male heroes, their roles ultimately subservient to those of their fathers or husbands, brothers and sons. If I ever wrote a book, I remember thinking, I would place women in the forefront of the action. I would uncover the story that lay invisible between the lines of the men's

exploits (Banerjee xiv-xv). The revisionist tendencies break and simultaneously revive the existing class, caste, gender and even religious stereotypes by employing critical and creatively progressive reinterpretations. Indian writers of late have been experimenting with the mythological genre generally by fusing it with the other modes of writings also and using Indian epics as “their base stories in Indian fantasy fiction” and have given it “prime importance completely abstaining from the popular fantasies of the west, like ‘Harry Potter’ or ‘The Lord of the Rings’” (Kulkarni 714). Revisionism, especially in mythology, gained wider popularity among Indian fiction writers and readers. The modern renditions show the power of perception and how the story can change because of that. Indian youth is often caught unaware of their rich heritage of mythologies and stories from the *Mahabharata* and Ramayana. On the contrary, Western myths and legends such as Robinhood, King Arthur and his Roundtable, vampires, Greek legends or witches and wizards have found special place and interest in the conscious of youth (Sinha 132).

The title of the play *Andha Yug: The Age of Darkness* can be literally translated as *The Blind Age*, owing to the reflective thoughts on blindness, ignorance, darkness, and collusion which reverberate at the heart of the play and directs us towards the absence of vision that characterizes entire eras along with individuals. The play take precedence into the context of violence that ensued during the partition of India and Pakistan that led to loss of lives in millions and transcends into the motif of showcasing the vainness of war and greed around the world (Bala 335). *Andha Yug* by Dharamvir Bharti is a verse play segregated into 5 acts alongside a prologue, an epilogue, and an interlude. The first act of the play starts on the evening of the 18th day of the war. The Kaurava clan is overcome by darkness and gloom. Gandhari and Dhritarashtra grieve over the loss of their sons, and Gandhari points her finger at Krishna for

hypocrisy. In the meantime, Vidura comments that she has turned cynical owing to the loss of her children. In addition, the Old Mendicant, who prophesied the victory of Kauravas, regretfully admits his error and acknowledges the power of omniscient Krishna. The second act introduces the character of Sanjaya to the readers, who is overwhelmed by the thought of revealing the news of the defeat of the Kauravas. The primary survivors from Kauravas' side include Ashwatthama, Kritavarma, and Kripacharya. Drona's son Ashwatthama is consumed by revenge owing to the loss of his father because of Yudhishtira's half-truth and swears his only dharma is to kill. He also ends up killing the Old Mendicant for his false prophecy out of his immense rage. The third act of the play begins with Sanjaya informing Gandhari and Dhritarashtra about the vanquished Kauravas. This scene is followed by the dramatic entrance of Yuyutsu, the only Kaurava who took the Pandavas' side. Conversely, Gandhari curses and mocks him for his betrayal. Ashwatthama, on the other hand, brings the news of Duryodhana's defeat. The aid provided by Krishna to Pandavas, irrespective of the violation of dharma, makes Balarama label Krishna "an unprincipled rogue" (Bharati 79). In addition, Ashwatthama comes across an event of an owl killing a sleeping crow, which provides him with the idea to lead an attack on the Pandava camp while they are asleep. The interlude of the play includes the ghost of the Old Mendicant, who remarks on the darkness of the age. The fourth act of the play commences with Ashwatthama, who makes a desperate attempt to enter the Pandava camp but is stopped by Shankara. However, he begs for mercy, and Shankara blesses him. Sanjaya uses his divine power to narrate the destruction caused by Ashwatthama to Gandhari, which amuses her. Although later, Sanjaya loses this divine power. Gandhari removes her blindfold when Ashwatthama visits her to empower his body by making it as hard as a diamond. Thereafter, Ashwatthama releases the Brahmastra to destroy the Pandava clan by targeting Uttara's womb and killing the unborn child.

Krishna comes as a saviour and saves Uttara's unborn child, and curses Ashwatthama with immortality. Krishna is initially cursed by Gandhari, claiming the destruction of the entire Yadava clan, but later realises her mistake and apologises. The final act starts a few years after the war ends, where Yudhishtira is on edge despite getting the throne and questions the victory of the Pandavas. Gandhari, Dhritarashtra, and Kunti die in a forest fire, and Yuyatsu also meets his tragic death in the later part of the play. During the epilogue, a hunter mistakes Krishna's foot for a deer and releases his arrow, which kills him. The death of Krishna marks the descent of the world into darkness, which is asserted by the chorus. The chorus ends the play with the mention of the seed of duty, freedom, honour, and virtuous conduct, which is prevalent inside everyone, and it needs to be nurtured to save the future of mankind.

The war in the *Mahabharata* lasted for eighteen days during which millions of lives were lost. However, the Kauravas were deemed the malicious and obdurate aggressors, the violation of dharma was practiced by both sides inclusive of the lack of codes of honour, good conduct, and virtue. Furthermore, Yudhishtira, also referred to as Dharmaputra, the most virtuous Pandava and the embodiment of dharma indulges in unethical acts. On the fifteenth day of the Kurukshetra battle, Krishna commended Yudhishtira to state that Ashwatthama has been killed to Drona. The statement or half lie uttered by Yudhishtira was a “crooked stratagem”premeditated to mentally cripple the invulnerable Drona (Stewart 114). The Pandavas in fact killed a war elephant named Ashwatthama to fulfil their plan. In addition, Yudhishtira went on to utter in a hushed tone, “the beast and not the son,” he nevertheless was in violation of his pledge to act with virtue even under dire circumstances (ibid.). Drona believed that Yudhishtira could never lie and dropped his weapons owing to the sorrow incurred after hearing

about his son's death and was killed. Dhristadyumna took this opportunity as Drona sat in meditation and beheaded him, which was yet again a gross violation of the rules of war.

Both sides in the war violated

the code of honour...

the Kauravas perhaps more than the Pandavas. (Bharati 27)

The abuse of the established war norms could be considered as the cause of marking an end to the Dwapara Yug and the downfall of "whatever is good and gentle and beautiful" (Bharati 27). The code of honour in war were something everyone revered and considered abiding by it but these norms were manipulated by many major and minor characters. The manipulation caused by the characters for their personal gain rendered these norms futile in the context of what everyone refers to as Dharma-yuddha. Ashwatthama in his murderous rage refuses to be held accountable for his actions and says:

From now on

my only dharma is:

'kill, kill, kill

and kill again!'

Let that be

the final purpose

of my existence! (Bharati 54)

When myth is demythologized, it ceases to be about the world and turns out to be about human experience of the world. Demythologized, myth ceases to be an explanation at all and becomes an expression, an expression of what it 'feels' like to live in the world. Myth ceases to be merely primitive and becomes universal. It ceases to be false and becomes true. It depicts the human condition. (Segal 48) The revisionist texts have a vital role in contributing to any sort of alteration that is required in a community and active consciousness of the citizens, since any deliberate change in the traditional structures of the society in India has to be mindful of the legislation of the revered epics.

Conclusion

Literary revisionism along with the notion of reworked copy, appropriation, voyage or afterlife that indulges a certain amount of revisiting and transformation indicate intertextuality amid a recent work and an older canonical piece of literature (Eisenhauer 3). Bharti in *Andha Yug* uses various excerpts from the *Mahabharata* to draw attention to the dangers of self-enchancement through the implementation of an anti-war allegory. The play provides insights into human beings' competence for ethical action, kindness during atrocious situations, settlement, and revelation of ways in which people fall prey to disparagement and malice of a dispirited and blind age. In addition, the play also provides an account of the cost incurred owing to society's failure to put an stop to the vicious cycle of revenge and, in place, choose the path of redemption, which is constantly available despite the worst scenarios. The play puts the impetus on how Krishna's appearance in the midst of the insanity of fellow human beings remains undeterred. However, when these fellow humans choose to jointly rebuff the voice of reason and wisdom, it

leads to the denigration of the battle upon them and eventually leads to mass melee on the battlefield of Kurukshetra. Though there is a thin line in understanding this phenomenon as a revivalist or revisionist, the oscillation in its narratives between breaking and reviving certain class, caste, gender and religious stereotypes through seeming critical and creatively progressive reinterpretations makes an interesting case of the dangers of ideological imaginations (in this case synonymous with mythical imaginations) becoming utopian. The play effectively highlights all the incidents related to violence and has associated the disgrace to the society as a whole. It has quite efficiently captured the pre-existing turmoil amidst the ordeal of self-enchancement represented through the narrative of the Kauravas and their constant struggle of clawing their way out of the vicious cycle of vengeance into the ethicality of redemption.

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